CASE STUDY

C&O Designs: Running a Print-on-Demand Shop with an AI Agent Team

A case study of C&O Designs, a one-person print-on-demand shop on Etsy and TikTok Shop, fulfilled through Printify and operated by an AI agent team with human approval gates. As of November 9, 2026, Eastern Time, the catalog held 64 active Etsy listings and about 44 TikTok Shop products. The shop is new and has not made a sale yet. This study describes the operating system, the volume it already handles, and estimated hours saved — not a revenue result.

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Early-stage and pre-revenue

As of November 9, 2026, Eastern Time, C&O Designs had received no orders and $0 in revenue on either channel. Traffic is still modest. The value so far is operational: a two-channel catalog, a repeatable production line, and guardrails that keep weak or unprofitable ideas from going live.

64
Active Etsy listings
Confirmed after the November 9 afternoon drop

44
TikTok Shop products
40 confirmed November 6, plus 4 published November 9

0
Orders to date
$0 revenue on both shops

85–90
Estimated hours avoided
Mid-October to November 9, from assumptions below

BUSINESS	C&O Designs, a one-person print-on-demand shop
CHANNELS	Etsy shop and TikTok Shop, fulfilled through Printify
CATALOG MIX	Seasonal bilingual holiday apparel, home goods, personalized gifts, and printable holiday planners
OPERATING MODEL	An AI agent team drafts and operates the shop; the owner approves batches and handles exceptions
AS OF	November 9, 2026, Eastern Time

The problem

A one-person print-on-demand shop looks simple from the outside: upload a design, wait for an order, and let a fulfillment partner print and ship it. In practice, the work never stops. Someone has to research what is selling, design original artwork, write listings, set prices that still make money after platform fees, answer customers, keep the books, and watch both storefronts for flags, expired logins, and listings that never actually went live.

C&O Designs sells on two channels at once. Physical goods — apparel, totes, ornaments, and similar items — are fulfilled through Printify on Etsy and TikTok Shop. Digital products, such as printable holiday planners and party-game kits, are Etsy-only instant downloads. That split adds handoffs: a design may need a listing on one channel or both, different fee math, and, for personalized gifts, a manual check so a name is on the item before it is printed.

For a single owner, the bind is time. Doing this work by hand competes with everything else in the day, so the catalog stalls, or quality slips, or prices quietly go underwater. The aim of the agent team is not to remove the owner from the business. It is to take the research, production, monitoring, and bookkeeping off that person's desk, and to leave the owner with decisions: what to publish, what to cancel, and when to step in.

How the agent team works

The shop is run by a small AI agent team with specialist roles and a single orchestrator. Nothing new is published until the owner approves the batch. The general manager checks in with the shop manager each morning and brings the owner in only when something is urgent.

ORCHESTRATOR	**Online Shop Manager** Runs the production line, assembles review packages, publishes after approval, checks for orders throughout the day, and files the daily report.
RESEARCH	**Online Shop Research** Finds product ideas, reads competitor listings, and proposes prices at or below the market median.
DESIGN	**Online Shop Designer** Creates original artwork and realistic mockups. Files stay unpublished until the owner signs off.
LISTINGS	**Online Shop Listing Creator** Writes titles, tags, and descriptions, and packages photos and digital files for each storefront.
PRICING	**Online Shop Pricing** Compares proposed prices with similar live listings and flags anything that would miss the profit rule.

FINANCE	**Online Shop Accountant**	Checks fee, cost, and shipping math, including sale-price scenarios, against a $3 minimum profit per item.
SUPPORT	**Online Shop Customer Service**	Watches the shop inbox and is set up to personalize an order before it goes to print. It is woken only when there is a real order or message.
GENERAL MANAGER	**Jarvis**	Runs the morning check-in with the shop manager, verifies important claims, and escalates to the owner only when a decision or a sign-in is needed.

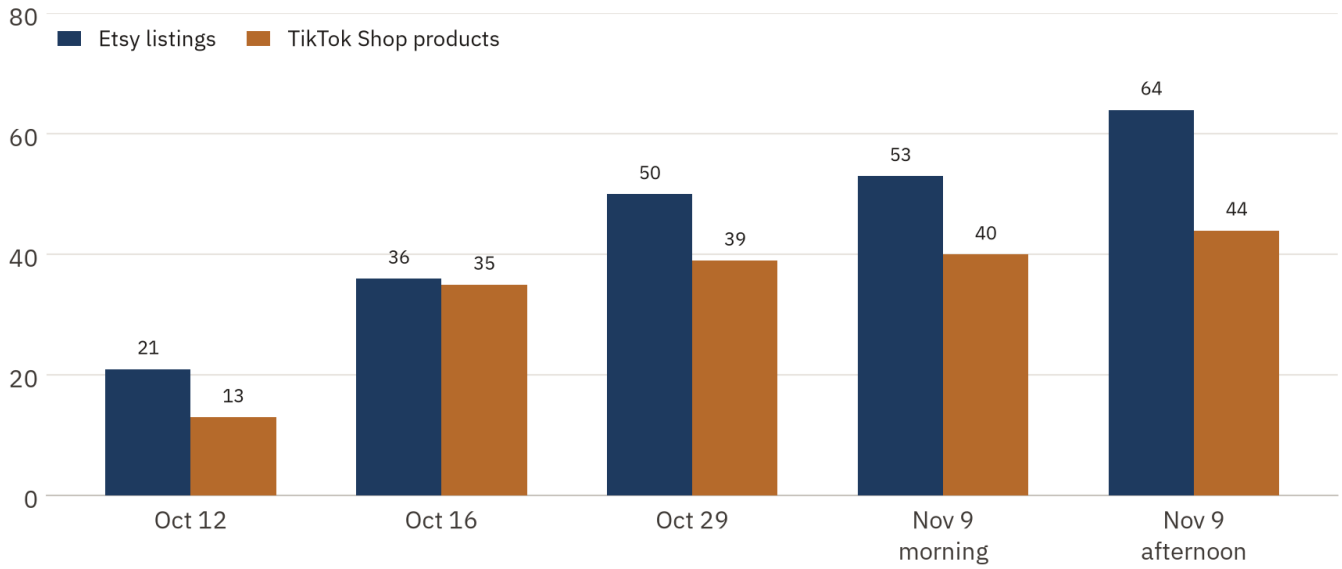
A weekly batch, and any special drop, follows the same path. Roles that were not earning their keep — including specialist search-engine, inventory, and shop-social roles — were later retired so the team stayed small.

1. **Research proposes a short list**
   Ideas have to clear demand and pricing tests. Lines that cannot hold a $3 profit, or that conflict with a standing rule, are dropped before anyone designs them.
2. **Design and listing work run on the short list**
   The designer produces original art and mockups. The listing creator writes channel-specific copy and prepares uploads. Trademark and language checks happen before a package is called ready.
3. **Pricing and accounting confirm the numbers**
   Every size and color has to at least break even. List and sale prices are checked against platform fees, fulfillment cost, and the $3 profit floor.
4. **The owner approves the batch**
   The shop manager sends a review package — designs, prices, and any flags — and waits. The team does not treat another agent’s go-ahead as the owner’s approval.
5. **The shop manager publishes and reports back**
   Approved items go live on the right channel. The manager confirms what published, what failed, and whether the storefront counts actually moved.

Volume handled

Catalog counts are from shop dashboards. The November 9 afternoon TikTok figure is inferred, as noted below.

The team has been operating the shop since at least early October 2026. In just under a month, the catalog grew from a small opening assortment into a two-channel storefront that is updated on a weekly cadence, plus occasional special drops.



The last TikTok column is 40 products confirmed on November 6, plus four tees published on November 9. A fresh seller-dashboard count was not available that afternoon, because the seller sign-in had expired. Etsy's afternoon count of 64 was confirmed when the holiday-list drop went live, around 1:20 p.m. Eastern Time.

WAVE	WHEN	WHAT WENT LIVE
Personalized gift launch	Mid-October	Ten personalized items. By October 16 the catalog stood at 36 Etsy listings and 35 TikTok products.
Digital planners	Mid-October	Seven Etsy-only printable and spreadsheet planners.
Weekly apparel batch	October 26	Seven seasonal bilingual holiday apparel listings, published as the owner approved.
Reduced weekly batch	November 2	Two seasonal bilingual tees on both shops. A larger planned drop, including a family pajama line, was cut because costs would have broken the profit floor.
Weekly batch	November 9	Six printable holiday downloads on Etsy and four seasonal tees on TikTok Shop.
Holiday-list drop	November 9, about 1:20 p.m. ET	Six printable Christmas-list and letter sets on Etsy.

Those five later waves added 32 unique products and 41 channel listings after the October 16 snapshot: 28 new Etsy listings, which took the shop from 36 to 64, and additional TikTok publishes, including four tees that were TikTok-only. Several other designs were researched or drafted and then held or cancelled, so production volume is a little higher than the live catalog shows.

Daily operations sit on top of the batch work. The shop manager files a morning report covering orders, traffic when it can be pulled, and blockers. Order checks run every three hours during the day so a new sale would be noticed quickly, even though none has arrived yet.

WINDOW	CHANNEL	TRAFFIC	ORDERS
30 days ending October 29	Etsy	74 visits, 138 listing views, one abandoned cart	0
October 23–29	TikTok Shop	293 impressions, 5 clicks	0
November 1–6	Etsy	13 visits, 16 listing views	0
November 3–9	Etsy	17 visits, 24 listing views, 0% conversion	**0**
As of November 6	TikTok Shop	Lifetime views still concentrated on a handful of older products; seller stats were not refreshed after that date	0

> **The bottleneck is discoverability, not production**
>
> A mid-October review found that shoppers barely see the listings. About 74 Etsy visits across 50 listings worked out to roughly 1.5 visits per listing per month, and the shop's items were not appearing in the first page or so of results for its main niches. A short Etsy Ads test on a few listings produced essentially no clicks. Promotion is set up through creators at a 10% commission, but there have been no affiliate-driven sales yet.

Hours and cost saved

Estimates only. Assumptions are listed first so the arithmetic can be checked.

The team does not time-track each task, and the shop's assistant usage was not isolated from the owner's overall assistant plan, so this page does not invent a dollar savings figure. The hours below are an estimate of the owner time it would have taken to do the same documented work by hand, from mid-October through November 9, 2026.

TASK	ASSUMED MANUAL TIME
Research and competitor pricing	25 minutes per product
Design and mockups	60 minutes per product
Listing copy, tags, photos, and upload, one channel	35 minutes per listing
Profit and fee check	10 minutes per product
Publishing the same product to a second channel	15 minutes
Daily shop operations: orders, inbox, flags, and stats	30 minutes per day
Periodic bookkeeping	45 minutes per week

Applied to the documented mid-October to November 9 waves — 32 unique products and 41 channel listings — those rates come to about 70 hours of production work. Daily operations over the same stretch, plus light weekly bookkeeping, add about 15 to 20 hours. Together, that is roughly 85 to 90 hours of owner time avoided in about four weeks.

The earlier catalog already stood at 36 Etsy listings and 35 TikTok products by October 16, and the same team had been building it. This estimate does not add those earlier listings, so the four-week figure is conservative relative to the full stand-up of the shop.

The owner is not removed from the work. Batch approvals, marketplace sign-ins, and a small number of exceptions still require a person. What changes is the shape of that time: review and decision, rather than research, design, data entry, and daily checking.

> **No dollar cost is claimed**
> A plan price or a freelance hourly rate would have to be assumed or pulled from a blended household plan, so it is omitted. The honest comparison at this stage is hours: the team can now produce a ten-to-sixteen-listing week and still watch both shops every day, which is not realistic for one person doing the work by hand after hours.

Monitoring and failure handling

The operating rule is to trust patterns only after they are checked, and to bother the owner only when a person has to act. Several real failures in the first month show how that works in practice.

1. **Morning check-in, exceptions only**
   Each morning the general manager checks in with the shop manager on orders, listings, and blockers. The owner is not copied on routine status. If a sale comes in, a listing fails to publish, or a sign-in expires, that is when the owner is asked to step in.

2. **Verify claims instead of trusting a dashboard count**
   On November 9, after six new Etsy downloads were published, the shop's active-listing count rose by only four, from 53 to 57. Rather than assume two listings had failed, the team checked each new listing individually and confirmed all six were live. The later holiday-list drop was watched the same way: the count moved from 58 to 64, exactly six, around 1:20 p.m. Eastern Time.

3. **An expired seller sign-in blocked stats, not publishing**
   The TikTok seller login on the shop team's computer expired after a November 6 sign-in. That blocked fresh TikTok statistics, a planned sale setup, and review of products flagged for attention. Publishing through the fulfillment partner still worked, which is how the four November 9 tees went live anyway. The fix is an owner sign-in, not a workaround.

4. **Flagged products are fixed or held, not ignored**

   TikTok has repeatedly marked a small number of products as needing attention. In one case, a color name in the listing did not match the name the platform uses for that color; the team corrected it and resubmitted, and the live listing stayed up in the meantime. In another, an update was rejected for inconsistent product information while the existing live version was left alone, pending the owner's decision. Remaining flags were still open on November 9 because the seller sign-in had expired.

5. **A $3 minimum profit floor is the pricing guardrail**

   Every new product, and every sale price, is checked against a $3 minimum profit per item. That rule has already changed the catalog: a family pajama line was cancelled because the cost was too high, some apparel could not take a deep discount without losing money, and older listings are audited against the same floor. Digital products, which have no print cost, are still priced at or below the competitor median and have to clear the same profit test after platform fees.

6. **Quality gates before publish**

   Batches get a trademark screen and, for bilingual listings, a language pass before they are offered to the owner. Products have been renamed or reworded when a phrase was risky. Personalized orders are set to wait for a manual check so a name can be placed on the design before it prints. There have been no such orders yet, but the path is in place.

7. **Design the checks so they stay cheap to run**

   When assistant usage hit its weekly cap, scheduled shop checks paused until the period reset. The team responded by retiring unused roles and by waking customer service only when a real order arrives, so empty checks do not burn the budget.

Lessons and next steps

Next steps are the open operating items as of November 9, 2026, Eastern Time.

The first month produced a clear lesson: the agent team can add listings faster than the market can find them. That is a success for operations and a warning for strategy. The catalog, the approval gates, and the profit floor are working. Demand is not yet.

LESSON	WHAT IT CHANGES
Production is no longer the bottleneck	A ten-to-sixteen-listing week is now routine. Further growth depends on search visibility and promotion, not on making more files.
Approval gates are worth the pause	The owner still sees every batch. Unprofitable or risky ideas are cancelled or rewritten before they reach a storefront.
Dashboard numbers can lag	A count that does not move by the expected amount is a prompt to verify each item, not a reason to republish or to assume success.
Logins fail independently of fulfillment	Analytics and promotions can go dark while publishing still works. Treat sign-in health as its own checklist item.
Keep the owner for exceptions	Morning reports and empty order checks stay inside the team. The owner is asked to act when a sale, a failure, or a sign-in requires a person.

Next steps, as of November 9, 2026, Eastern Time:

Restore the TikTok seller sign-in — Waiting on owner

Needed before fresh statistics, the planned sale, and flagged-product review can resume.

Clear products that need attention — Blocked on sign-in

A small set of TikTok products was still flagged when the seller login expired.

Keep the weekly cadence under the same gates — Ongoing

Continue the research-to-approval loop, including profit-floor audits of older listings.

Work on discoverability — Open

The shop is easy to stock and hard to find. A short ads test did not move the needle; creator promotion is in place but has not produced sales yet.

Keep the first-order playbook ready — Ready

The inbox is monitored, and personalized orders have a manual path. There have been no customer messages, because there have been no sales.

> **What this case study is, and is not**
>
> C&O Designs shows that a one-person print-on-demand shop can be operated day to day by an AI agent team, with the owner concentrated on approvals and exceptions. In about a month the team stood up and expanded a two-channel catalog, published in weekly batches, and caught real operational failures without turning every issue into an owner interruption. It does not yet show that the model produces sales. That test is still ahead.

Sources

1. Figures come from the shop dashboards and the shop team’s operating reports, current as of November 9, 2026, Eastern Time, except where a figure is labeled as older or inferred.
2. Hours-saved figures are estimates based on the assumptions stated in this page. They are not time-tracked hours, and no dollar cost is claimed.